

Should we be polite to ChatGPT?

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Introduction

According to data released this year, "A majority of U.S. teens say they use AI chatbots, including about three-in-ten who do so daily" (Atske 2026). Even teachers are using it to help grade and offer feedback to students; a 2025 survey found that "53 percent of English language arts, math, and science teachers indicated that they used AI for school" (Doss et al. 2026). As the use of AI has increased, people have recognized that there are different ways and approaches to talk with AI. In fact, ChatGPT releases a "report card" at the end of the year, similar to Spotify Wrapped, that tells you things about your "most common questions" and also your "chat style". When my friend received her end-of-year "ChatGPT Wrapped" report, it bluntly called out her chat style: "Are you blind?" It criticized her for not being polite enough in her prompts. She showed it to me, half-joking and half-annoyed. At first I laughed too, but that moment has lingered in my mind for a long time. As a non-native English speaker who often struggles to express ideas clearly, I realized how easily a machine could judge someone's tone as "rude" or "inappropriate". This got me thinking: Should politeness to chatbots matter? This essay argues that we should be polite to AI chatbots such as ChatGPT because it produces more accurate and higher-quality information, it preserves human civility, and it helps reduce the long-term risk of uncontrolled AI development.

Accuracy

One of the reasons it is important to be polite to AI chatbots is that it generates more accurate and higher-quality responses. This has been demonstrated by researchers in recent years. Yin et al. (2024) provides solid evidence for this argument. In their cross-lingual study, they argue that the level of politeness used in a prompt can affect the efficiency of LLM (large language models) in interpreting and responding to a user's requests. This study tested several models such as GPT - 3.5, GPT - 4 and Llama in three completely different language environments: English, Chinese, and Japanese. The researchers found that impolite prompts frequently led to a noticeable decline in model performance of LLMs, which led to increased bias, incorrect answers, or refusal to answers (ibid.). On the other hand, moderate politeness in prompts can significantly improve the quality of tasks such as summarization and language comprehension (ibid.).

Nathan Bos, reflecting on similar findings, points out that while extreme rudeness can distract the model's attention through unusual language patterns, basic politeness can serve as a

conversational marker for clarification and transition (Bos 2025). Polite conversational markers-phrases like "please" and "thank you"-more clearly enhance the structure of the conversation. The clearer the structure, the easier it is for AI models and LLMs to accurately respond to the prompt (ibid.). For instance, "please" clearly indicate a request, while "thank you" marks a shift in context. In this way, politeness can yield more accurate results by creating clarity in the prompts. However, accuracy is not the only argument for being polite to AI chatbots.

Civility

Politeness is a habit that, like any habit, needs to be practiced and fostered. Small practices have broader impacts. This is true for politeness. Psychologist Nathan Bos applies Barbara Fredrickson's "Broaden and Build" theory to human approaches toward AI models (ibid.). The "Broaden and Build" theory "describes how consistent positivity can create virtuous spirals" (ibid.) Bos suggests that when we communicate with artificial intelligence, choosing positive and polite language might quietly cultivate our novel and creative behaviors, ideas and social relationships (ibid.). Therefore, every polite prompt becomes a small exercise for fostering good character and behavior (ibid.). This may not only improve the accuracy of AI responses but also effectively enhance the way we handle problems and deal with people in society.

Beyond the question of politeness as a positive habit, there is also the question of morality. Yes, it might take more time to be polite, but what's the hidden cost of not doing so? According to Moritz Sahlender, writing for the London School of Economics, "When we interact with AI using only short, functional commands such as "do this" or "write that," we may begin to normalize a style of communication that prioritizes efficiency over reflection" (Sahlender 2025). When you communicate in a direct commanding style, it might become normalized in the way you talk and interact with people in your personal life, as individuals you are trying to "get" stuff out of, rather than form a genuine connection with. This isn't to say that the goal is to form a positive relationship with AI and ChatGPT; rather, the way we treat the platform can carry over to the way we treat others. Education scientist Moritz Sahlender states:

If we drop politeness in digital interactions simply because 'it's just a machine,' we may also be changing how we relate to others and, over time, to ourselves, shaping not just our habits but our dispositions. Being polite to AI isn't about pretending it has feelings. It is about choosing a way of speaking that reflects a certain attitude: one of care, respect, and intentionality. This choice isn't for the machine's benefit, it is for our benefit, for safeguarding our moral character. (2025)

This moral character he refers to should matter to us all, because our actions and the way we talk to AI and others says a lot about us to the world. If we normalize being impolite online, who's to say we don't start talking this way to everyone? Pedagogy and social media expert Dave Webster writes,

[H]ow we interact with AI systems shapes our character. Each time we communicate with technology, we're practicing patterns of interaction that spill over into our human relationships. Digital civility is a moral training ground. We don't need to believe AI has feelings to see the value in treating these systems with courtesy. The true benefit is to ourselves and our communities-maintaining the habit of respect regardless of who (or what) we're addressing. (2025)

I agree with this sentiment and see everything in life as a "moral training ground" he refers to; just because AI isn't human doesn't mean it isn't worthy of our respect. Dobariya and Kumar, who studied the impact of being polite to LLMs, also agree with the idea of treating AI with some respect for respect's sake, writing, "We do not advocate for the deployment of hostile or toxic interfaces in real-world applications. Using insulting or demeaning language in human-AI interaction could have negative effects on user experience, accessibility, and inclusivity, and may contribute to harmful communication norms" (Dobariya and Kumar 2025). If we develop "harmful communication norms" with AI, these norms can translate into our everyday lives.

Backlash

Lastly, there's the idea-perhaps extreme-that if we don't treat AI with respect, it might later respond in a hostile way. A Fortune survey found that amongst those that said it's important to be polite to AI, "12% admit to hedging against a hypothetical AI power grab" (Kurbalija 2025). That number might be surprisingly high depending on one's perspective, but it's worth thinking about why people answered it that way. While the survey didn't ask those who were scared of an AI-takeover why they are scared of it, I believe that their beliefs have some merit: After all, AI is relatively new and rapidly expanding. Everyone knows what AI is, but not everyone is sure how it's created or if it imitates its users. Moreover, movies like *I Robot* and *Her* lead people to have second thoughts about all things robotic or AI-centric. Regarding the former, it had a massive impact on how much people are willing to give up their own agency for "convenience": *I Robot* depicts robots revolting against and turning on their human creators. There's even an article, written in *Fast Company*, about how this movie predicted the current dangers of AI. In it, the author concludes, "Our AIs might not have robotic faces and bodies just yet, but when they do, will we be safe? Or, more importantly, what happens if we wait for the robots to materialize before we rein in their underlying technology?" (Nover 2024). It's not a surprise that there's a segment of the population that is hesitant to hand everything over to AI.

Even though it's undeniable that it's critical to be polite to ChatGPT and AI in general, it's worth mentioning the other side of the argument. For one, the OpenAI CEO, Sam Altman, recently acknowledged that users saying things like "please" and "thank you" to chatbots is expensive: In an exchange on the social media platform, X, a user wrote to him, "I wonder how much money OpenAI has lost in electricity costs from people saying 'please' and 'thank you' to their models," and Altman responded with "Tens of millions of dollars well spent-you never know" (Forlini

2025). The article from PCMag further explains that "AI chatbots require immense energy, many times more than a typical Google search. According to a Goldman Sachs report on data center power, a Google search consumes 0.3 watt-hours of electricity; one ChatGPT search consumes 2.9 watt-hours" (Ibid.). So, the more words used in a search, the more energy that is needed.

While some research suggests that being polite to AI and ChatGPT is a waste of time, the evidence presented in this essay would suggest that it's worth taking an extra second or two to make sure that we don't misuse or mistreat this technology. Overall, it's more accurate, more ethical and potentially lifesaving to use words like "please" and "thank you" and avoid being too direct or inappropriate with it. After all, there's no real harm caused by being polite, whether one's talking to someone in person or to an online chatbot.

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